

DEBATING CONVIVIALITY: ALFRED TUNA SNIDER'S ILLICHIAN APPROACH TO DEBATE & THE UNIVERSITY

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Alfred “Tuna” Snider’s legacy lives on in his scholarship on game theory and debating practices as well as in the many lives he influenced in his efforts to spread the tools of debate across the globe. But perhaps something less well-known is the deep influence of the work of Ivan Illich on Tuna’s scholarship and his approach to academic debate. Best known for his critiques of the modern, compulsory education system, Ivan Illich was a philosopher and social critic of Western culture and its industrial institutions. One of Illich’s important keywords is “conviviality,” which is an ethical value and method for evaluating society’s relationship to its “tools” with regards to whether or not they prioritize “individual freedom realized in personal interdependence” (Illich, 1973, p. 11). Conviviality serves as a significant concept that shapes Illich’s pathways to other possible ways of living, being, and thinking in the world that challenge the taken for granted assumptions and rituals endemic to the dominant institutions of Western society. Conviviality also, in my view, best helps to express the thinking that drove Tuna’s unique approach to academic debate, and it will be the primary theoretical focus of this essay.

While many are aware of Tuna’s most popular academic course, the Rhetoric of Reggae Music, few outside of his students at the University of Vermont

knew of his Rhetoric of Ivan Illich course.¹ Tuna's commitment to exposing undergraduate students to the broader work of Ivan Illich is rare. Outside of Illich's work on education, and particularly his book *Deschooling Society* (1971), his work has otherwise received little scholarly attention and is not widely taught in undergraduate classrooms. And most certainly, Illich and his theories have played little to no role in either debate arguments or approaches to debate instruction.

The remainder of this short essay aims to explore the influence of Ivan Illich on Tuna Snider's debating pedagogy and his relationship to the activity. Drawing on archival research of Tuna's course materials, Illich's theories, and my personal experiences as Tuna's former student and, later, assistant debate coach, I argue that Illich's theory of conviviality played a central role in shaping Tuna's approach to debate and his vision for how it should be used and promoted globally. Conviviality best describes how Tuna framed debate as a tool capable of resolving our most pressing and catastrophic problems (from global warming to political apathy); enabling people to think and do for themselves rather than depend on the views and ministrations of technocratic elites, experts, and managers; and to create a more socially just and equitable society through fostering and cultivating citizens' potentials to engage in and demand a participatory democracy throughout the globe and, indeed, on their own debate teams and

1 Yet, arguably, even Tuna's course on reggae music, and perhaps his deep love of the genre, is inextricably intertwined with his fascination with the work of Ivan Illich. Indeed, I would argue that Illich's critique of modern, industrial society drove his interpretation of reggae music's social critiques and alternatives as well, although this argument is beyond the scope of this essay.

campuses. In order to forward this argument, I first give a brief overview of Illich's theory of conviviality and how it fits within his broader work before then turning to Tuna's uptake of this theory and how it manifested itself in his scholarship, teaching, and, especially, debate pedagogy. Finally, I outline the ways in which these ruminations on Tuna's pedagogy might be useful for making debate more convivial in the future.

Illich & Conviviality

Although Illich's work is largely absent from the bulk of contemporary scholarly discussion outside Education, his work has recently received a modicum of greater traction. Amidst educational reform movements and, especially, changes in technology, Illich's work is being given new light venues such as *The International Journal of Illich Studies* as well as scholarly symposiums organized around his work (Levi, 2012) and book collections reflecting on the continued and, indeed, renewed relevance of his work in post-industrial society (e.g. Hoinacki & Mitcham, 2002). Still, Illich's work is difficult to categorize and can by no means be said to garner a major influence on contemporary scholarly debates. As Hoinacki notes, "Illich has not produced a coherent social theory; he has not written a major historical study; he will not be remembered as an important twentieth-century philosopher. But he has made startling contributions in each of these areas" (Hoinacki & Mitcham, 2002, p. 1). Thus, for his devotees, though perhaps few in number, his work continues to provide vital and productive resources informing their more contemporary takes on the roles of institutions and technocratic managerialism that persists in post-industrial society. Illich's numerous works spanned the topics of gender (1982), education (1971), medicine (1976), work (e.g. 1977, 1981), and other institutions that structure modern, industrial

life. His work provides a critical lens on the ways in which these institutions subordinate human life to the machinations of capital, consumption, and the technocratic interests of elites. Illich's work also offers pathways for deinstitutionalization, in which he suggests both philosophical and practical alternatives to our dependency on institutions, machines, and elite control.

In his book *Tools for Conviviality* (1973), Illich suggests conviviality is an ethical framework by which to evaluate whether our "tools"—from "drills, pots, syringes, brooms, building elements, or motors" to "productive institutions such as factories that produce tangible commodities...and productive systems for intangible commodities such as those which produce 'education,' 'health,' 'knowledge,' or 'decisions'" (pp. 21-22)—"promote survival, justice, and self-defined work" (p. 13) that enables "individual freedom realized in personal interdependence" (p. 11). But what is most important for Illich is not so much a philosophy of tools and technologies as it is an ethical evaluation of those tools—how to decide whether or not a tool is useful, when to discard a particular tool, or when and how to reconstruct a particular tool in order to make it of greater use. Here, his conception of conviviality becomes an ethical framework and an evaluative tool, one that emphasizes personal autonomy, but in a way that is bound up with interdependence, along with "survival, justice, and self-defined work" (Illich, 1973, p. 13).

Centrally, conviviality is juxtaposed against industrial productivity and the demands that tools place on individuals in ways that become exploitative and alienating of one's creative labor, where, "as the power of machines increases, the role of persons more and more decreases to that of mere consumers"

(Illich, 1973, p. 11). Illich suggests, "I choose the term 'conviviality' to designate the opposite of industrial productivity. I intend it to mean autonomous and creative intercourse among persons, and the intercourse of persons with their environment; and this in contrast with the conditioned response of persons to the demands made upon them by others, and by a man-made environment" (1973, p. 11). He critiques especially the ways in which tools become used as instruments for fixing problems that only create more of those same problems. In particular, Illich was concerned with the ways in which people cede their power to the professional elite and to experts, abdicating their own creative freedom and investing their time, energy, and bodies into the use of tools that maintain and reproduce industrial and professional hierarchies.

Instead, Illich enjoins us to reevaluate our use of these tools, and to invest our time and energy into tools that foster conviviality:

Tools foster conviviality to the extent to which they can be easily used, by anybody, as often or as seldom as desired, for the accomplishment of a purpose chosen by the user. The use of such tools by one person does not restrain another from using them equally. They do not require previous certification of the user. Their existence does not impose any obligation to use them. They allow the user to express [their] meaning in action. (1973, p. 23).

A tool should be discarded, then, if it furthers the interests of elites at the expense of the marginalized, if it enables personal freedom but requires the subordination of others: "if we give people tools that guarantee their right to work with high, independent efficiency, thus simultaneously eliminating the need for

either slaves or masters and enhancing each person's range of freedom" (Illich, 1973, p. 12). Ultimately, then, Illich is calling for what he calls a "convivial reconstruction," or as Foucault suggests, a "radical reversal of the relationships between individuals and tools or machines" (Foucault, 2000, p. xxii). This reversal would "give priority to the protection, the maximum use, and the enjoyment of the one resource that is almost equally distributed among all people: personal energy under personal control" (Illich, 1973, p. 12). Illich therefore calls for the valuation of the knowledge of peers and the everyday over experts and institutional knowledge, as well as a commitment to collective political process and "mutual self-care" (Foucault, 2000, p. xxii). Convivial reconstruction would "invert the present deep structure of tools" by valuing tools to work *with* rather than tools to work *for* (Illich, 1973, p. 10), especially those that enable us "to move and to dwell" (Illich, 1973, p. 11). His critique is therefore not one of technology (in a broad sense) itself, but more so the ways in which technology is used, distributed, and valued. A convivial society, for Illich, is one in which all members are able to control in the most "autonomous action by means of tools least controlled by others," and where the decisions about these tools and their uses fall under democratic control, "governed by political process rather than by decisions of experts" (Illich, 1973, p. 12).

Debating Convivially

Though Illich does not emerge as a strong and present figure in Tuna's scholarship or in his numerous online debating materials, it is clear that Illich remained an important figure for him. Most notably, this is evident in his Rhetoric of Ivan Illich class, which he taught at the University of Vermont (UVM), almost every year, for over 20 years. This suggests that the

work of Illich, which he encountered in the 1970s and 1980s, was not something that he abandoned. It seems there was something important for Tuna about regularly returning to Illich's work and introducing his students to this unique perspective. As he noted in a blog post at the end of the semester in the spring of 2014, "Every time I hold this class it changes me. I always learn something new and I become someone else, I think a better person" (Snider, 2014).

For those familiar with Tuna's mission to spread debate globally, these ruminations on Illich's theories of tools for a convivial society should ring familiar. Indeed, it is clear that Tuna very much saw debate as a convivial tool—one that enabled the most autonomous action with a tool least controlled by others: one's voice. Debate for Tuna was very much a tool to work *with* rather than a tool to work *for*. Although he was deeply competitive, he structured his team and trainings not around competitive success (in which debate was an end in and of itself), but rather around debate as a tool, a life skill by which to participate in democratic processes.

It was not only the practice of debate that he valued as a convivial tool, but also the tools that made up that larger machinic process of debating, whether it was the use of machines to engage in research, the means to get to and from tournaments, tabbing systems, the evidence briefs utilized in order to make arguments, and, indeed, the arguments themselves. For each of these, and all of debate's tools, Tuna promoted a convivial use—they were to be tools to work *with* that promoted personal freedom and autonomy, but in such a way that autonomy was realized in personal *interdependence*. This was why it was so important for him to provide access to training tools that would be free and available to all on the various websites he maintained. As an

early web adopter, he saw immediately the potential of this tool to foster interdependent and autonomous learning, to free oneself from the authority of experts. And debating instruction, offered free to all as well as inviting users to offer up their own trainings as well, again helped to foster a convivial debating society, aimed at providing individuals with tools to work with to build a better society.

Tuna was against the use of tools that were not easily adaptable across time and place. He saw the need for debate tools that we can each use, as seldom or often as we wish, for purposes that we choose rather than those chosen by others, but in which our use does not impinge on their uses by others. As a coach, he encouraged his students to “speak truth to power,” but he did not prescribe what the content of those truthful arguments were. It was enough for him to provide the tools to these debaters in which they could formulate their own truths and, indeed, to “think for themselves.”

If those tools became subject to an inversion, where they became ends in and of themselves that escalated the crises they were meant to resolve, Tuna discarded them. He was indeed a debate innovator, but he was able to innovate because he knew when to leave certain tools behind. In an interview Tuna gave shortly before his passing, he noted a few of his regrets, including his willingness to embrace the speed of policy debate as well as mutual preference judging (LaHood-Burns, this issue). Suggesting that they were initially meant to be tools that fostered independent thinking and autonomy, that furthered good argument and critical thinking, he saw in the results of their practice a debating society that fostered elitism and professional, expert knowledge that seemed to perpetuate the very same types of exclusions they were meant to resolve.

Underlying my desire to return to Tuna’s Illichian approach to debate is my sense that debate is at a critical juncture. In particular, I draw attention to two underlying sites of transformation that debate is undergoing and to which all those involved in debate will be pressed to respond to:

1. The globalization and transnationalization of debate along with the resistance to its histories in white supremacy: debate’s spread to both new local and global spaces calls into question long held assumptions about the speaking subject, as well as the various forms of “white flight” that have resulted from these antagonisms and the broader ways in which these struggles get articulated to the role of universities in liberal education (see Reid-Brinkley, 2008)
2. The neoliberalization and corporatization of the university and of debating societies: this leads to increasing needs for debating societies to acquire external funding (or for debaters to pay their own ways) and to market themselves as a good “return on investment,” depend on increasingly precarious and exploited labor, treat students as commodities. This is also related to the increasing commoditization of debate through the globalization of debate training as a profit-generating industry

How we respond to these transformations will influence whether debate will be a tool aimed toward a more convivial society, or if it will be the tool to which we remain subject in the production and reproduction of the post-industrial and neoliberal university system to which debate is becoming increasingly subservient.

In particular, I think current debaters, coaches, and directors ought to ask themselves, their universities,

their squads, and their networks how we might make debate more convivial? What might convivial reconstruction of debate look like, feel like, sound like? What tools have outlived their use? How might debating tools be freed to be more accessible to the use of all, but in such a way that their use does not impinge on their use by others? How might we avoid prescribing changes in debate that only serve to reify the very problems that those changes were meant to cure? Ultimately, how can we liberate debate as a tool that enables us to both “move and to dwell” (Illich, 1973, p. 11), to enable “the most of the energy and imagination each has” (p. 12), such that we are accorded the “freedom to make things among which [we] can live, to give shape to them according to [our] own tastes, and to put them to use in caring for and about others” (p. 11). I think these are questions worth answering, and I am thankful to Tuna for encouraging me to make debate a more convivial space for myself and for future debaters.

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